

The Label Decoder

Consumer Rising · 50 ingredients to watch, and the exact words to look for

HIGHER CONCERN High Fructose Corn Syrup

Look for: HFCS, HFCS-55, Glucose-fructose syrup, Isoglucose
A cheap liquid sweetener made from corn starch

HIGHER CONCERN Red 40

Look for: Allura Red AC, E129, FD&C Red No. 40
One of the most widely used artificial colors in US food — candy, drinks, cereals, and snacks

HIGHER CONCERN Yellow 5

Look for: Tartrazine, E102, FD&C Yellow No. 5
The bright yellow dye in candy, drinks, chips, and even some medicines

HIGHER CONCERN Partially Hydrogenated Oils

Look for: PHOs, Partially hydrogenated soybean oil, Shortening
The main source of artificial trans fat

HIGHER CONCERN Brominated Vegetable Oil (BVO)

Look for: BVO, E443
Used to keep citrus flavor mixed in some sodas and sports drinks

HIGHER CONCERN Potassium Bromate

Look for: Bromated flour, E924
A flour additive that makes bread rise higher and look whiter

HIGHER CONCERN BHA

Look for: Butylated hydroxyanisole, E320
A preservative that keeps fats in chips, cereal, and gum from going stale

HIGHER CONCERN Sodium Nitrite & Sodium Nitrate

Look for: Sodium Nitrite, Sodium Nitrate, E250, E251, E249, E252, celery powder, celery juice powder, cultured celery juice
The preservatives that keep bacon pink, hot dogs shelf-stable, and deli meat free of botulism

HIGHER CONCERN Acesulfame Potassium (Ace-K)

Look for: Acesulfame Potassium, Acesulfame-K, Ace-K, Sunett, E950
A calorie-free sweetener found in diet sodas, sugar-free baked goods, and other 'diet' products

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HIGHER CONCERN

Sucralose

Look for: Sucralose, Splenda, E955

The sweetener sold as Splenda, spread across the 'sugar-free' aisle — diet drinks, gum, baked goods, and tabletop packets

HIGHER CONCERN

Red 3 (Erythrosine)

Look for: Red 3, Erythrosine, FD&C Red No. 3, Red No. 3, E127

The bright cherry-red dye in candy, frostings, and baked goods — and the additive behind the biggest US food-dye regulatory act...

HIGHER CONCERN

Yellow 6 (Sunset Yellow)

Look for: Yellow 6, Sunset Yellow, Sunset Yellow FCF, FD&C Yellow No. 6, E110

One of the most widely used dyes in US candy, sodas, and snacks

HIGHER CONCERN

Blue 1 (Brilliant Blue)

Look for: Blue 1, Brilliant Blue, Brilliant Blue FCF, FD&C Blue No. 1, E133

The blue in candy, sports drinks, and baked goods — often mixed with yellows to make green

HIGHER CONCERN

BHT (Butylated Hydroxytoluene)

Look for: BHT, butylated hydroxytoluene, butylhydroxytoluene, E321

A synthetic antioxidant that keeps fats and oils in cereals, snack foods, and packaged goods from going rancid

HIGHER CONCERN

TBHQ (Tertiary Butylhydroquinone)

Look for: TBHQ, tertiary butylhydroquinone, tert-butylhydroquinone, t-butylhydroquinone, E319

The preservative that keeps crackers, potato products, and oil-heavy baked goods from going rancid — EWG found it in over 2,700...

HIGHER CONCERN

Propyl Gallate

Look for: propyl gallate, E310

An antioxidant that protects fats and oils in meat products, frozen foods, and candy — usually teamed up with BHA and BHT

WORTH KNOWING

Sodium Benzoate

Look for: E211, Benzoic acid

A preservative that keeps sodas, juices, and condiments from spoiling

WORTH KNOWING

Aspartame

Look for: E951, NutraSweet, Equal

The sweetener in most diet sodas and sugar-free gum

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WORTH KNOWING Titanium Dioxide

Look for: E171, CI 77891

Makes candy, frosting, and coffee creamer look bright white

WORTH KNOWING Parabens (Propylparaben & Methylparaben)

Look for: propylparaben, propyl paraben, methylparaben, methyl paraben, propyl p-hydroxybenzoate, E216, E218
Antimicrobial preservatives in tortillas, muffins, and some processed meats — the same chemical family used in cosmetics

WORTH KNOWING Caramel Color III & IV

Look for: caramel color, caramel colour, caramel coloring, caramel colouring, ammonia caramel, sulfite ammonia caramel, E150c, E150d

The brown in colas, soy sauce, and baked goods — the most widely used coloring in food by weight

WORTH KNOWING Azodicarbonamide (ADA)

Look for: azodicarbonamide, ADA, azobisformamide, E927a, E927

The 'yoga mat chemical' — a dough conditioner that makes bread rise higher and fluffier, best known from the 2014 campaign that...

WORTH KNOWING Phosphates (incl. Phosphoric Acid)

Look for: phosphoric acid, sodium phosphate, sodium acid pyrophosphate, trisodium phosphate, dicalcium phosphate, E338, E339, E450, E451

A huge family of additives doing dozens of jobs — leavening baked goods, emulsifying processed cheese, adding tang to colas

WORTH KNOWING Mono- and Diglycerides of Fatty Acids

Look for: Mono- and diglycerides, monoglycerides, distilled monoglycerides, mono- & diglycerides of edible fats or oils, E471

One of the most widely consumed emulsifiers in processed food — it keeps cakes, biscuits, mayonnaise, and other fats and sauces...

WORTH KNOWING Polysorbate 80

Look for: Polysorbate 80, polysorbate-80, tween 80, polyoxyethylene sorbitan monooleate, E433

An emulsifier used in ice cream, baked goods, and creamy sauces — and one of two emulsifiers tested in a much-discussed 2015 mo...

WORTH KNOWING Carboxymethylcellulose

Look for: Carboxymethylcellulose, cellulose gum, sodium carboxymethylcellulose, E466

A thickener and emulsifier that gives ice cream its body and keeps baked goods and sauces smooth — backed by two independent li...

WORTH KNOWING Saccharin

Look for: Saccharin, Sweet'N Low, sodium saccharin, E954

A zero-calorie artificial sweetener with a long, instructive history: a 1970s rat bladder-cancer scare put warning labels on ev...

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WORTH KNOWING Erythritol

Look for: Erythritol, E968

A sugar alcohol marketed in keto and 'sugar-free' products as the safe sweetener — now at the center of a live scientific debat...

WORTH KNOWING Xylitol

Look for: Xylitol, birch sugar, E967

A sugar alcohol often derived from birch, used in sugar-free candy, 'keto-friendly' baked goods, and toothpaste — the second su...

WORTH KNOWING Sulfites

Look for: Sulfites, sulfur dioxide, sodium sulfite, sodium bisulfite, sodium metabisulfite, potassium bisulfite, potassium metabisulfite, E220, E223

Preservatives that keep dried fruit bright and wine from spoiling — safe for most people, but genuinely dangerous for asthmatic...

WORTH KNOWING Blue 2

Look for: Blue 2, FD&C Blue No. 2, indigotine, E132

One of the less-studied synthetic blue dyes, used in candy, drinks, baked goods, and pet food

WORTH KNOWING Sodium Aluminum Phosphate

Look for: sodium aluminum phosphate, SALP, E541

The leavening acid in self-rising flour, baking powder, cake mixes, and processed cheese

WORTH KNOWING Interesterified Oils

Look for: interesterified soybean oil, interesterified palm oil, interesterified oils

The industry's quiet replacement for trans fats in margarines, baked goods, and confectionery — made by chemically rearranging ...

LOWER CONCERN Monosodium Glutamate (MSG)

Look for: MSG, E621, Yeast extract, Hydrolyzed protein

A flavor booster for savory food

LOWER CONCERN Carrageenan

Look for: E407, Irish moss

A thickener from red seaweed in chocolate milk, ice cream, and plant milks

LOWER CONCERN DATEM

Look for: DATEM, E472e, diacetyl tartaric acid esters of mono- and diglycerides

One of the most common dough conditioners in commercial bread and buns — it makes loaves rise higher, stay soft longer, and sur...

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LOWER CONCERN

Sodium Stearoyl Lactylate

Look for: sodium stearoyl lactylate, SSL, E481, sodium stearoyl-2-lactylate

DATEM's quieter partner in the bread aisle — an emulsifier that strengthens dough, softens crumb, and keeps commercial loaves f...

LOWER CONCERN

Disodium Inosinate & Disodium Guanylate

Look for: disodium inosinate, disodium guanylate, E631, E627, I+G

The umami amplifiers hiding behind MSG on snack and soup labels — they make savory flavors taste several times stronger than MS...

LOWER CONCERN

Natural Flavors

Look for: natural flavors, natural flavoring, natural flavouring

The most common two-word mystery on US labels — a legal category, not a health claim, covering dozens of undisclosed flavor che...

LOWER CONCERN

Artificial Flavors

Look for: Artificial flavors, Artificial flavor, Artificial flavoring

A catch-all label word for flavor chemicals made in a lab rather than pulled from food — and you usually cannot tell what is ac...

LOWER CONCERN

Maltodextrin

Look for: Maltodextrin

A highly processed starch used as a filler, thickener, and carrier in everything from salad dressing to 'sugar-free' snacks

LOWER CONCERN

Sorbitol

Look for: Sorbitol, E420, Sorbitol syrup

A sugar alcohol used to sweeten sugar-free gum, candy, and diet foods — the concern here is concrete and well documented: too m...

LOWER CONCERN

Calcium Disodium EDTA

Look for: Calcium disodium EDTA, Calcium disodium edetate, EDTA, E385

A preservative that works by grabbing onto stray metal ions — tiny amounts of iron and copper in food that would otherwise turn...

LOWER CONCERN

Propylene Glycol

Look for: Propylene glycol, Propane-1,2-diol, E1520

A moisture-holding solvent that keeps cake mixes soft and carries flavors and colors evenly through food — a different chemical...

LOWER CONCERN

Carmine

Look for: Carmine, Cochineal extract, Cochineal, Carminic acid, Natural Red 4, E120

A pink-to-red color made from the cochineal insect — the 'natural' color with a documented, if rare, severe-allergy risk

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LOWER CONCERN

Diacetyl

Look for: diacetyl, 2,3-butanedione, artificial butter flavor, artificial butter flavoring

The chemical behind the butter flavor in microwave popcorn and many baked goods — the one behind 'popcorn lung'

LOWER CONCERN

Calcium Propionate

Look for: calcium propionate, E282, preservative 282

The mold inhibitor behind long-lasting bread — the quiet preservative in the bread aisle

LOWER CONCERN

Green 3

Look for: Green 3, Fast Green FCF, FD&C Green No. 3, E143

The quiet one of the synthetic dye family — a green color used in some candies and beverages, and not widely used at all

LOWER CONCERN

Allulose

Look for: allulose, D-allulose, D-psicose, psicose

The new 'rare sugar' sweetener in keto products — about a tenth of sugar's calories, without the same blood-sugar spike

LOWER CONCERN

Dimethylpolysiloxane

Look for: dimethylpolysiloxane, polydimethylsiloxane, PDMS, E900, silicone oil

A silicone-based anti-foaming agent that keeps hot cooking oil from foaming over — a processing aid you will likely never taste...